



Number Crunching The Mobile Gaming Industry

- ❑ The mobile gaming market was expected to make about £13.8m (Rs 113.16 crore) by the end of 2004, according to a report by InStat
- ❑ Many Indian kids see mobiles as must-have gadgets. This is the target audience for games
- ❑ Experts reckon that 22 crore people across the world will be playing games on their mobiles by 2009
- ❑ Overall, the Indian mobile gaming industry will experience growth from three million annual game downloads by the end of 2004, to 367.2 million annual downloads by 2009, and revenues will rise to \$336 million (Rs 1,461.6 crore) by 2009

fact that almost 70 per cent of the income for the top three mobile gaming companies in India—Indiagames, Mobile2Win and Paradox Studios—comes from selling their games overseas, this might not be an entirely outlandish thought. Indiagames and Mobile2Win also provide games to many service providers across Asia, Europe and North America.

Friends Of The Games

Revenues for these companies have been on the rise, and the industry overall has also seen a substantial rise in game downloads. But what kind of games work best in India? “Bollywood-based games are doing very well right now, as are games that are event-based—like the ones we create for festivals such as Dussehra and Diwali,” says Hiranandani.

Vishal Gondal, founder and director, Indiagames, agrees. “Bollywood is overrated, but the games we create for them do work. Unfortunately, their life is not as much as that of some others. Bollywood movies often lack a theme or a story, and are hence not as attractive for most gamers. At the end of the day, it’s content that’s selling, not Bollywood.”

While gaming enthusiasts are taking to the new way of playing, service providers also need to be ‘gaming friendly’. It is being said that Bharti Televentures (Airtel) are the most game-friendly network, followed by Hutch and Tata Teleservices. “This is mainly due to the circles these providers are present in. Bharti, Hutch and Tata are all present in the metro circles, where the penetration of GPRS is higher. Mumbai, Gujarat, Delhi, Punjab and Haryana are the top five circles for game downloads,” says Hiranandani.

The Players

The average age of mobile gamers is a little higher than the average age of computer gamers. “Ages 16 to 27 are our primary target group, followed by the 25-35 age group,” says Gondal. The second group of gamers prefers the slightly quieter and sportier games, including Chess and Cricket. But for the former, anything goes. “Racing, warrior games and action

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Vishal Gondal,
Founder-Director,
Indiagames.com

games are their favourite,” says Hiranandani.

A look at the break-up of the types of games sheds more light on what’s popular in the Indian mobile gaming arena. (See ‘The Pack Leaders’)

Interestingly, Hollywood games are the most popular, and as Gondal says, “These games have a better theme to go with them. Hollywood producers understand mobile gaming as a market and as a money-making proposition, and treat it so. Creating games for a Hollywood movie can start even six months prior to the release. In case of Bollywood movies, producers sometimes come in a week before the release, and that much time is hardly enough for a quality game.”

While Hollywood has its share of classics, including *Prince of Persia*, on mobile, Bollywood is just waking up to the reality and opportunities mobile games are offering. “The *Sholay* game is the only one at present that has any chance of becoming a classic. The rest are made just so they coincide with the release of the movie and create some more hype,” says Hiranandani.

Money Matters

Games for mobiles are normally priced between Rs 50 and Rs 149. And contrary to belief, games priced higher have seen greater downloads.

“On a particular day late last December, we saw 8,500 downloads of games priced at Rs 150 while those at Rs 100 were downloaded about 3,600 times. But games priced at Rs 50 were downloaded only 400 times. The problem here is that the Rs 50 games are downloaded only once and they don’t get popular. Word of mouth is a very strong tool in this business, and games priced at Rs 150 benefit from this, thanks to the quality,” says Gondal.

Games end up being priced this high thanks to the monies spent by these companies in acquiring rights to various titles or properties. More often than not, these are non-exclusive deals, but still cost a lot of money. “Rights to Hollywood movies and characters are the most sought after thing because the brand sells the games. This number can be as high as almost 50 per cent of all games sold. This is where we really compete,” says Hiranandani.

While the GSM market is flourishing, CDMA is not far behind. Reliance Infocomm offers games for free as of now, but will start charging soon. Paradox Studios, a Reliance company, is

currently developing games for them in addition to contracts from international carriers, including Verizon. “With Reliance, we see greater downloads daily, almost to the tune of five to seven lakh a day sometimes. So far, with Reliance offering them for free, we have created about 55 titles for them,” says Salil Bhargava, chief marketing officer, Paradox Studios.

